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From Independence to Military Dictatorship: Burma 1948–1962

The modern history of Burma emerges with the completion of independence from Great Britain. The elections of April 1947 solidified the Anti-Fascist People's Freedom League (AFPFL) as the legitimate party to lead Burmese independence. The Constituent Assembly declared that Burma should be an independent republic with key constitutional guarantees of social, political, and economic justice. Furthermore, all power was to emanate from the people and minority rights were to be safeguarded. The tragic assassination of national hero General Aung San along with six cabinet members on July 19, 1947, did not derail the independence process.

POLITICS IN BURMA: 1948–1958

On January 4, 1948, at 4:20 A.M., the independent Union of Burma came into existence. Prime Minister U Nu took over a fragile state. Members of the AFPFL would dominate Burmese politics during this initial decade. U Nu was considered to be an inept leader who lacked the administrative abilities as well as the charisma of Aung San. Early electoral success could not conceal the troubling turmoil brewing in Burma. Multiple problems, including the issue of federalism, as well as civil wars based on ethnic and ideological lines, would haunt early Burmese independence. Furthermore, external threats from powerful neighbors prompted the military to take an early and significant role in Burmese society. U Nu appointed General Ne Win to several cabinet posts, as both the military and police presence increased substantially in the postindependence period.

The new Burmese political system was unitary. Multiple ethnic groups felt uneasy in a Burman-dominated political system. Alienated Karens,